Secretary who, on instruction from Rusk, would discreetly approach Secretary-General Thant to publicly propose the deal, which the United States would then accept. The reliability of this account has been questioned. The British historian Mark White discovered that the UK ambassador at the UN, Sir Patrick Dean, caught wind of Cordier's involvement in high-level exchanges between the UN and the US government several days before Kennedy is supposed to have given Rusk his instructions.[54] The specifics of Cordier's involvement recorded in Dean's report differ from those in Rusk's account. Rusk maintains that only he, the President and Andrew Cordier knew what happened. Is Rusk reliable? As noted in his memoir, he states that the Turkish missiles were already being removed before the Kennedy-Dobrynin meeting, which is not true. Rusk also lied to Congress on the subject.[55] It may well be that Cordier's role was more extensive than thought. It may be that evidence from British records does not undermine Rusk's claims. Maybe it does. Another puzzle.

'The Cordier ploy' has, nevertheless, reinforced the view that JFK was determined to 'go the extra mile for peace.' An alternative interpretation is that he was merely preparing the ground for a course of action, just as mobilisation of US forces did not in itself commit the President to an invasion. McNamara states (with customary certainty): 'I can guarantee that Kennedy had neither decided to invade Cuba nor decided *not* to invade Cuba. He hadn't made up his mind at that point what he would do next.'[56]

Kennedy also authorised an approach to Castro, exploiting the previous willingness of the Brazilian government to mediate in relations between the US and Cuba. Castro met with a Brazilian emissary on 29 October in an attempt by Washington not only to secure removal of the missiles, but to persuade Castro to abandon his links to Moscow, as well as to cease Cuban efforts to foment revolution in the region. The approach was poorly conceived, poorly co-ordinated, and ill-timed, and served mainly to sour relations between the US and Brazilian governments.[57]

What would have happened if the United States had attacked Cuba on or around 30 October 1962? Wars are, invariably, the least predictable of human activities, so any assessment is inherently speculative. What can be